▶ WEST BENGAL

JUTE TURNS GOLD AGAIN

A happy coincidence of good weather and astute central policy scripts a revival for struggling crop

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

GOLDEN AGES ARE USUALLY THINGS OF THE PAST. So it had long seemed for Bengal's jute story. Once vivisected down the middle by Partition, the Indian side had of late been stalked by dwindling returns, farm distress, locked mills and layoffs. But after years, with nature and official nurture working in unusual concert, the state's jute farmers are tasting a season of genuine profit.

The decisive factor: in two steps through June-August, New Delhi imposed restrictions on imports from Bangladesh. The extra demand created thus has fortuitously coincided with a season that is seeing an uptick in local supply. Excess rainfall, which damaged crops elsewhere, worked as a blessing for jute—the crop thrives on abundant water. The result: not only better yields but finer quality fibre, fetching prices unseen in recent years.

Jute cultivation and allied trades provide direct or indirect livelihood to around four million in Bengal. So, the year's bounty has generated more work in the labour-intensive processes of retting—submerging the stalks in water so as to disentangle the fibre from the wooden core—and then drying and bundling. That is boosting wages for farmhands all around Bengal. In hamlets, there is, for once, a sense of relief as orders flow in and payments arrive on time.

The price curve tells its own story. On September 8, jute was being sold at Rs 8,800 per quintal—that's a straight rise of Rs 3,000 from January 8. "Farmers are getting almost double of what they used to get until the corresponding period last year," says Sanjay Kajaria, former president, Indian Jute Mills Association.

THE OTHER BENGAL

Of India's annual requirement of around 7.5 million bales of jute, West Bengal contributes some 5.8 million bales, and Assam 700,000-800,000. The shortfall was met by imports from Bangladesh, whose production overtook India's last year. That sourcing had steadily undermined confidence among local farmers; many of them switched to other crops.

The import ban has changed that. As Jai Bagra of the Jute Baler's Association points out, "If this trend continues, it's possible that many farmers will return to jute farming." That guarded optimism runs like a glint of gold across Bengal's riverine tracts, where bundles of freshly dried fibre are once again drawing middlemen and traders. ■

GETTY IMAGES



RESURGENT CROP A labourer ties jute stalks in North 24 Parganas district in West Bengal



▶ GOA

THE HARD

The coastal state does not have

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IN THE GOA OF THE MIND, there exists a surplus of all good things—and every frame of leisure is fringed by a coconut palm or two. From a cool glass of sol kadi to fish curry to beach shack pina coladas, the sweet tinge of coconut milk tempers everything. In reality, though, Goa's state tree is struggling to cope with the rigours of playing everybody's favourite seaside Eden. Coconuts, of all things, are in crisis.

Goa needs an average of 100,000 coconuts every day but only around 40,000 are available locally. The rest—as much as 60